#6 Leadership as Content Creation
Where are ethics and substance gone?

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LEADERSHIP AS CONTENT CREATION

Where are ethics and substance gone?

A FOGGS Open Consultation Discussion Note

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Executive Summary

Attention has become a highly valuable commodity in the modern era. Political personalities focus on monopolizing public attention, even though negative publicity and outrageous statements, to win elections and get hold of power. Not all is lost, though. Determined and confident voices rooted in ethical principles have in the past prevailed and can still serve as a counterbalance, inspiring collective action and providing an alternative path forward.

Discussion Analysis

The Economics of Attention:
• Attention has become a highly valuable commodity in the modern era, akin to labour during the Industrial Revolution. While aggregated attention is immensely valuable, individual contributions are worth very little.
• Figures like Donald Trump and Elon Musk have mastered the art of monopolizing collective attention, often using negative attention as a tool to dominate public discourse.

The Shift in Political Strategy:
• Traditional political communication aimed at persuasion is being overshadowed by strategies that prioritize capturing attention, regardless of the content or consequences.
• Negative attention, such as trolling or outrageous behaviour, is easier to generate and more effective than positive engagement. This creates a dilemma for opponents: whether to engage and amplify the attention or ignore and risk irrelevance.

Leadership and Ethics in Politics:
• Modern leadership often focuses on gaining power rather than substantive governance. Leaders may prioritize election tactics over ethical or visionary policymaking.
• There is a perceived lack of transparency and trustworthiness in political communication, which has been exacerbated by new technologies that amplify manipulative tactics.

The Role of Vision and Utopia:
• Contemporary society lacks a collective vision of utopia or a positive future. This absence contrasts with historical periods where leaders and thinkers articulated aspirational goals.
• Effective leadership should involve presenting a vision for the common good and guiding people toward it, rather than merely seeking reelection.

Local Challenges and Global Implications:
• Participants highlighted challenges in small communities, where local voices struggle to gain visibility on national platforms without leveraging social media effectively.
• The global rise of populist and authoritarian figures underscores the need for strong counter-narratives from democratic leaders at all levels.

Countering Negativity with Positive Leadership:
• While figures like Trump and Musk thrive on negative attention, history shows that strong, moral voices can also capture public imagination (e.g., FDR, Ghandi, Zelensky).
• A determined and confident voice rooted in ethical principles can serve as a counterbalance to divisive rhetoric.

Norms and Accountability:
• There is a need to reaffirm fundamental norms of international conduct. For example, rejecting aggression against other countries (e.g. Russia's invasion of Ukraine or the US invasion of Iraq) must be unequivocally stated.
• Public figures spreading falsehoods or undermining norms (e.g. President Trump's comments about Canada) should be confronted directly to maintain accountability.

Takeaways

1. Attention as Power: In the modern "attention economy," controlling public focus is more critical than the substance of messaging. Negative attention has become a dominant strategy for gaining influence.
2. Leadership Crisis: Current political leadership often prioritizes short-term gains (elections) over long-term vision or ethical governance. This trend reflects a broader societal shift away from aspirational thinking.
3. The Role of Technology: Digital platforms have amplified manipulative tactics, making it easier for leaders to monopolize attention but harder for substantive voices to break through.
4. Counter-Narratives Are Essential: Strong, positive leadership rooted in moral clarity can effectively challenge divisive figures, if it is visible and consistent.
5. Local Voices Matter: Small communities face unique challenges in gaining visibility but can leverage social media to amplify their concerns.
6. Reaffirming Norms: Democratic societies must actively restate and uphold shared values to counteract the erosion of international norms by authoritarian rhetoric.
7. Hope for Change: While negative tactics dominate now, history suggests that powerful, ethical voices can still inspire collective action and provide an alternative path forward.